

PHISHING ATTACKS

Recognize fake emails, spot malicious websites, and respond safely.

ONLINE TRAINING MODULE

Includes real-world examples + interactive quizzes



Learning objectives

By the end, learners can pause before clicking and verify before sharing.

MODULE GOALS

- Recognize common phishing email red flags.
- Identify fake websites and risky URLs.
- Understand social engineering pressure tactics.
- Apply simple best practices to protect accounts.
- Practice with short quizzes and examples.

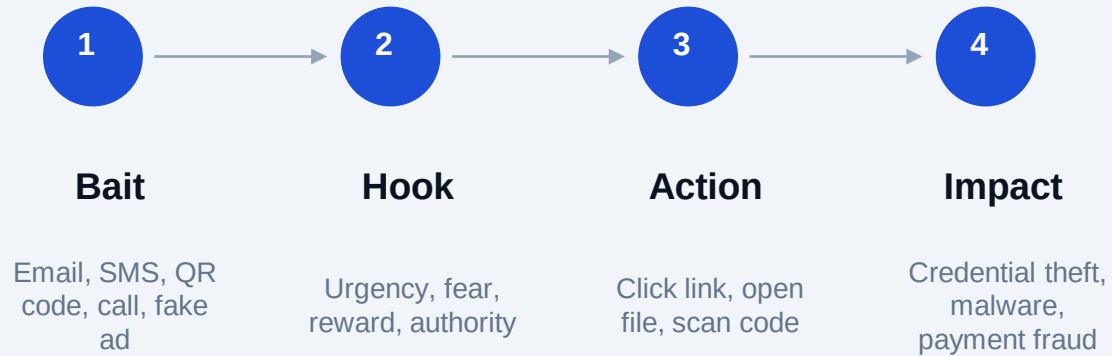
Why it matters: phishing/spoofing was among the top cyber-crime complaint categories reported to the FBI in 2024.



What is phishing?

A scam message that pretends to be trusted so you click, log in, pay, or share data.

ATTACK FLOW



Main idea: attackers exploit human trust—not only software weaknesses.



How to recognize phishing emails

Look for clusters of warning signs, not just one typo.

Sender mismatch

Display name looks familiar, but the actual address or domain is wrong.

Attachments

Unexpected invoices, ZIP files, macro documents, or “secure” PDFs.

Urgent pressure

“Act now”, “account locked”, “payment failed”, or threat of penalty.

Data requests

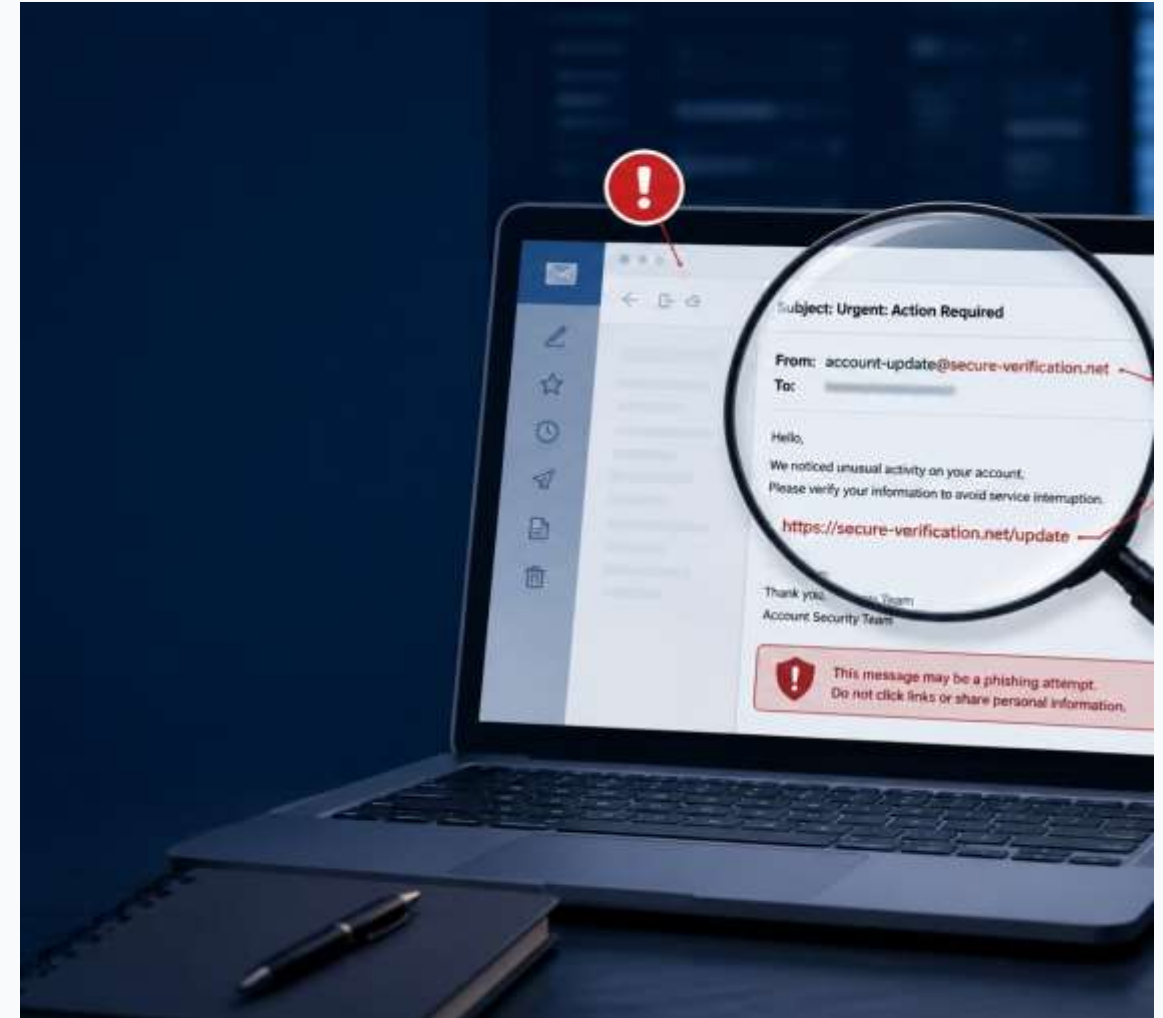
Asks for password, OTP, bank card, CNIC/SSN, or recovery codes.

Suspicious links

Hover/tap-and-hold: link destination does not match the claimed brand.

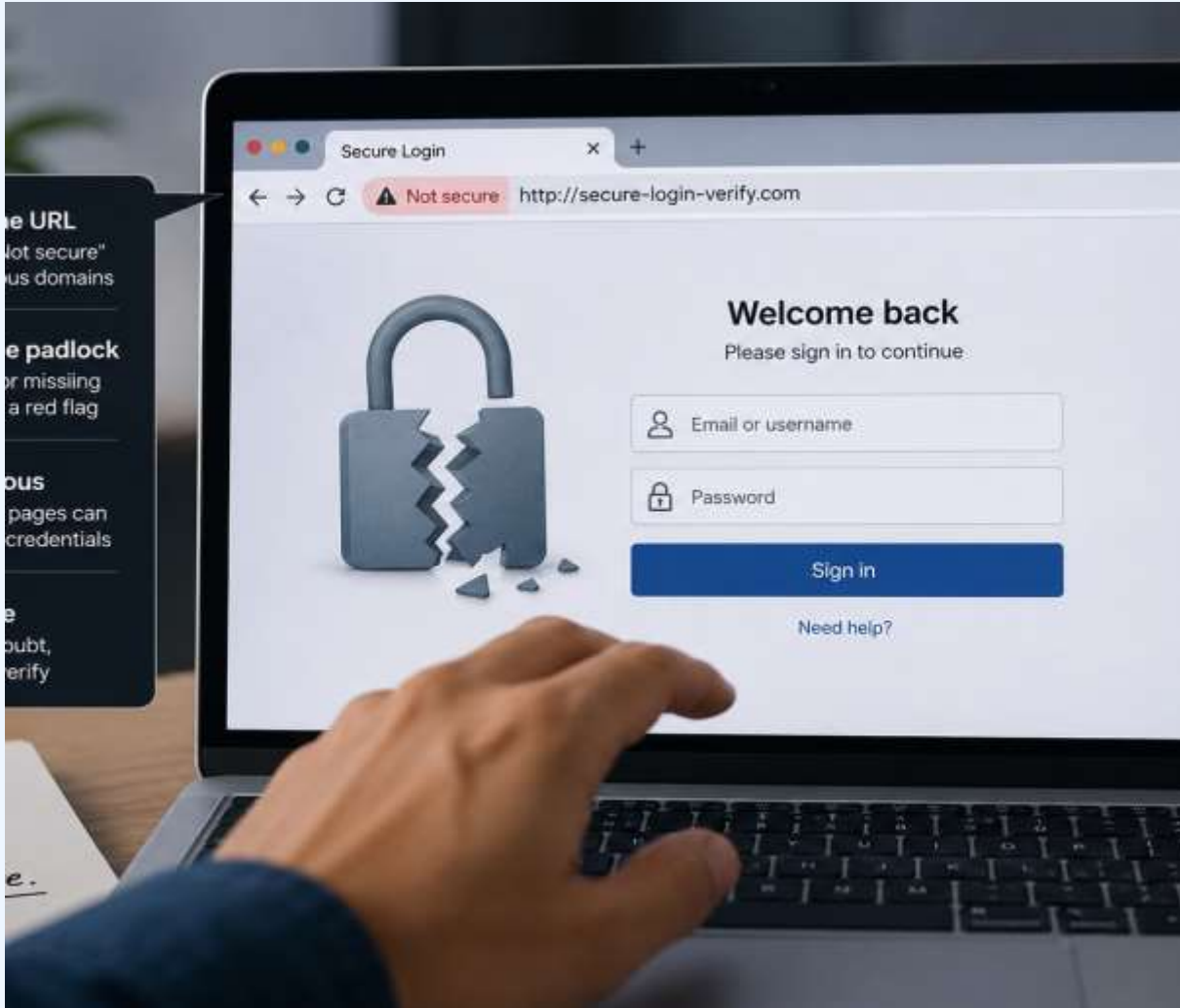
Generic wording

“Dear user”, odd tone, poor personalization, or unusual timing.



How to spot fake websites

Phishing websites copy real brands, but the URL and page behavior often reveal the trick.



WEBSITE CHECKS

- ✓ Read the domain carefully: paypa1.com ≠ paypal.com
- ✓ Do not trust the padlock alone; HTTPS can exist on fake sites.
- ✓ Avoid login pages opened from unsolicited emails or texts.
- ✓ Watch for fake pop-ups, forced downloads, or “support” chats.
- ✓ Go directly: type the address or use a saved bookmark.

Quick rule: When money, login, or personal data is involved, close the link and verify from a separate trusted channel.

Social engineering tactics attackers use

They push emotions first, logic second.

SOCIAL ENGINEERING

Authority	"Your manager / bank / university needs this."
Urgency	"You have 10 minutes before access expires."
Fear	"Your account has been compromised."
Reward	"Claim your prize / refund / scholarship."
Scarcity	"Only today — confirm now."
Trust hijack	Uses real logo, names, old email threads, or LinkedIn info.



Real-world examples to discuss

Use these as short classroom discussion prompts.

1. Fake government portals

Attackers clone official reporting portals or public-service pages to collect personal and banking data.

2. Toll / delivery smishing

SMS says “unpaid toll” or “package failed”; link opens a fake payment page.

3. QR-code phishing

A malicious QR code sends users to credential theft pages or malware sites.

4. Business email compromise

A fake executive/vendor asks for urgent bank transfer or invoice change.

5. Account reset lure

A fake Microsoft/Google/bank login steals username, password, and OTP.

Activity: For each example, ask: What emotion is targeted? What should the safe response be?

Best practices: Think → Verify → Protect → Report

Small habits prevent major compromise.

THINK

Pause before clicking. Ask: was I expecting this?

VERIFY

Contact the sender using a known phone/email, not the message link.

PROTECT

Use MFA, password manager, updates, and unique passwords.

REPORT

Use your organization's report button; report fraud to official channels.

Never share passwords, OTPs, backup codes, or card details through links sent in messages.



Interactive Quiz 1: Spot the red flags

Read the email. What are the three strongest warning signs?

From: Helpdesk <security-alert@university-login-support.com>
Subject: URGENT: Your account will be closed today

Dear User,
We detected unusual activity. Confirm your password and verification code now to avoid losing access.

Click here: <http://university-login.verify-now.co>

Regards,
IT Team

Options

- A. Suspicious sender domain
- B. Urgent pressure
- C. Requests password + code
- D. Message has a greeting

Correct: A, B, C

Trainer tip: Ask learners why “Dear User” alone is weaker evidence than a credential request.

Interactive Quiz 2: Safe or unsafe?

Choose the safest next action.

Scenario

You receive a text: “Your package delivery failed. Pay 80 PKR re-delivery fee today.” The link is a shortened URL.

What should you do?

- A. Pay quickly to avoid losing the package
- B. Open link in incognito mode
- C. Use the courier’s official app/site or helpline
- D. Forward it to friends to ask

Correct answer: C — verify independently.

If you clicked or shared information

Fast action reduces damage.



RESPONSE STEPS

- ✓ Disconnect from suspicious site; do not enter more data.
- ✓ Change the password from a trusted device/site.
- ✓ Enable/verify MFA and sign out of other sessions.
- ✓ Tell your IT/security team or bank immediately.
- ✓ Report the message and preserve screenshots/headers.
- ✓ Monitor accounts for unauthorized activity.

Do not feel embarrassed. Reporting early protects other people too.

Key takeaways

- ✓ Stop and verify before clicking.
- ✓ Treat urgent requests for money, passwords, or OTPs as high risk.
- ✓ Check domains carefully; do not rely on branding or padlocks alone.
- ✓ Use MFA + password manager; report suspected phishing quickly.

Sources for instructor notes

- FTC — How to Recognize and Avoid Phishing Scams
- CISA — Recognize and Report Phishing / Social Engineering guidance
- FBI IC3 — 2024 Internet Crime Report and Spoofing & Phishing guidance
- APWG — Phishing Activity Trends Reports
- OCC / NCSC — Consumer and organization phishing prevention guidance

End of module — discuss one phishing example you recently saw.